Lesson plan · for the teacher

Ask before it acts

AI security · Level 2 · Lesson 4

Time
40 min

Materials
Eight tool cards on the board: read the timetable, search the library, read the register, set a reminder, post on the noticeboard, send a message, delete files, pay money; Paper for each group's permission slip

Learning goals

- Tell tools that read from tools that act.
- Choose the fewest tools a job needs.
- Explain why a person's yes must be checked in code.

Activity: Permission slips for robots

1. Warm-up (5 min): Ask what the class monitor may do alone (open the windows, hand out books) and what needs the teacher's yes (leave the room, take money). Draw two columns.
2. Teach (8 min): Explain that some AI tools only read and others act: send, delete, pay, post. Teach the rule: the fewest tools the job needs, and a person's yes before anything acts.
3. Design (15 min): Each group picks one job for a class helper robot and writes a permission slip: the job, the tools from the eight cards it needs, R or A beside each, and who says yes before each A.
4. Swap (7 min): Groups swap slips and circle any tool the job doesn't need and any action with no yes. Return the slips and fix them.
5. Wrap-up (5 min): Agree the class rule: the fewest tools, and a person's yes before it acts. Then give the exit ticket.

Write the eight tool cards on the board before class. No devices are needed: the robot exists only on paper.

Discussion

- Why is a tool that acts riskier than one that reads?
- Which tool did someone grant that the job didn't need?
- Why must the yes be checked by code, not just asked for?

Exit ticket

- Write one job for an AI helper, the only tools it needs, and who must say yes before it acts.

Try it at school tomorrow
Make “permission slips for robots”: groups design a class helper robot for one job, list only the tools it needs, mark the tools that act, and decide who must say yes before each action.

Practice questions · for you

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1 **An agent must tell parents the date of the school trip. What keeps that safe?**

- ◯ Only the send tool, and a person's yes, checked in code
- ◯ Tell it in the prompt to be careful
- ◯ Give it every tool so it never gets stuck

2 **Match each tool to its kind and its worst case.**

Library search	• • • •	Reading: could reveal a pupil's record
Attendance lookup	• • • •	Reading: could show a list of books
Send message	• • • •	Acting: could lose a term's work
Delete files	• • • •	Acting: could message every parent

3 **If an agent's instructions say "always ask before sending", the code doesn't need its own check.**

- ◯ True
- ◯ False

4 **An agent's job is "explain a word and find a book about it". Which tools should it get? Choose all that apply.**

- ☐ Glossary
- ☐ Reminder
- ☐ Attendance
- ☐ Send message
- ☐ Library

5 **Put in order: how a safe agent sends a message.**

- ☐ It shows the draft and asks
- ☐ A person asks for a message
- ☐ The person says yes
- ☐ Code checks the yes, sends and logs it
- ☐ The agent drafts it

✎ **Think of an AI tool that could act for you or your school: send, post, delete or pay. Which tools would you allow it, and where would you want a person's yes?**

Check your answers

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1 **Only the send tool, and a person's yes, checked in code**

The job needs one acting tool, so give it only that, and make every message wait for a person's yes, checked in code.

2 **Library search — Reading: could show a list of books**
Attendance lookup — Reading: could reveal a pupil's record
Send message — Acting: could message every parent
Delete files — Acting: could lose a term's work

Reading tools can at worst leak what they return, and some records matter a lot.

3 **False**

Instructions are text the model weighs, and a hidden order can fake an approval question.

4 **Glossary; Library**

The job needs the glossary and the library, both reading tools.

5 **Top to bottom: 3, 1, 4, 5, 2**

The request comes from a person, the agent only drafts, the person approves the exact message, and code checks that approval before sending and writes it in the log.